

BEFORE

From the start of World War II, governments sought ways to unite people in the war effort. When the US entered the war in 1941 the Allied cause was bolstered.

PROPAGANDA

Governments at war mobilized their citizens with **propaganda**; posters were a favored means of communicating **war aims**. All sides used propaganda to encourage people in the **war effort** and **boost morale**.



US POSTER

THE ANGLO-AMERICAN ALLIANCE

The Alliance was signed in December 1941 as the US entered the war. It set up joint British and American military command for all Anglo-American operations. The pact was born of the close political understanding between the British leader, **Winston Churchill** << 392–93, and US president **Franklin D. Roosevelt** << 384–85. The two nations entered a period of cooperation, which helped Britain in the war.

Innovations in military technology played a key role in determining the outcome of World War II. One of the greatest battles of the war was fought at sea. The German navy began to target US merchant ships carrying weapons, raw materials, food, and eventually troops across the Atlantic Ocean to Britain. German submarines, or U-boats, sank three million tons of Allied shipping over the course of the war. Churchill later admitted that the threat to the lifeline of US supplies was the one thing that really terrified him; without it, Britain might have been starved into submission. The Battle of the Atlantic, as this theater of war became known,

was won partly by the development of longer-range aircraft that could reach U-boats. Support from the Canadian and US navies played a major role, as did better intelligence, and the development of centimetric radar to find submerged U-boats.

Desert warfare

Tanks and aircraft played a decisive role in the campaigns in North Africa, where mobility was crucial for crossing the deserts. Mussolini (see p.387) had wanted to extend the Italian empire by invading Egypt in 1940. Desperate to protect British interests in Africa, troops from Britain and Commonwealth countries (former British colonies, see

pp.346–47) were sent in to stop him. Initially the British drove the Italians back to Libya, despite Italy's superior numbers of troops and equipment. To aid its weaker ally,

1240 The number of days Australian troops held out under siege at Tobruk against Rommel's forces before being relieved by Allied troops.

Germany sent in the Afrika Korps under Field Marshal Rommel. By May 1941 he had won back all the territory lost by Italy. It was not until October 1942 and the British victory under

Total War

As the war in Europe raged on, the Atlantic Ocean and the deserts of North Africa became backdrops for fierce battles. Securing vital supply lines from the US enabled Britain and its allies to drive back the German and Italian troops. With the Red Army advancing from the east, Nazi Germany was surrounded.



Depth charge

Coastguards stand on the deck of the US Cutter *Spencer* watching the explosion of a depth charge blast a Nazi U-boat out of the water. The U-boat's target was the large convoy of merchant and troop ships seen on the horizon. Allied support and the advances in radar technology ensured Britain's Atlantic lifeline to the US and Canada stayed open.

Storming of Bardia 1942

The Allies captured territory held by the Italians with relative ease early on in the North African Campaign. Here, Australian troops storm the town of Bardia in Libya. German Field Marshal Rommel's Afrika Korps came to Italy's assistance and fighting continued in Egypt, Algeria, Morocco, and Tunisia.

